CONNECTICUT

The Constitution State



The coal smoke reached Wooster Square before the pushcart did. By the early 1900s, Frank Pepe was already a familiar sight in New Haven's Italian quarter, a young immigrant from Maiori steering a cart of flatbread through streets crowded with the families who had crossed the Atlantic for the city's factories and foundries. He sold apizza — the word carried over from Naples, pronounced ah-BEETS by everyone who bought it — charred rounds of dough dressed with little more than tomato, oregano, and a scatter of grated cheese, baked dark and blistered the way the old country liked them. It was cheap, it was fast, and it tasted like home to people a long way from theirs.

In 1925, Pepe traded the cart for a storefront on Wooster Street and lit an oven that would still be burning generations later. Coal-fired and brick-lined, it ran ferociously hot — hot enough to leave the underside of a pie freckled and crisp, to give the crust the char and chew that no home oven could match. For years he sold his tomato pies and his anchovy pies to a growing crowd, and he might have been remembered for those alone. But Pepe kept fresh littleneck clams on hand, sold by the dozen on the half shell, and the leap from raw clams on ice to clams on dough was a short one for a man who trusted his oven.

The white clam pie has no recipe of origin anyone bothered to write down, which suits it. Sometime around the middle of the century, Pepe shucked a handful of littlenecks straight onto a round of dough, added garlic, oregano, a slick of olive oil, and a dusting of grated Pecorino, and slid it into the coal fire. What came out had no tomato at all — just the briny snap of the clams, the bite of raw garlic gone sweet in the heat, and the smoke of the oven pulled through every bubble of the crust. It should have been strange. Instead, it became the thing people drove hours to eat, lining up outside the little shop on Wooster Street long before the doors opened, and it turned a tomato-pie man into a New Haven legend.

That legend is built on restraint, and so is the pie. There is no sauce to hide behind, no mountain of cheese, nothing to distract from clams that must be fresh and an oven that must be hot. Get those two things right and the rest takes care of itself. You don't need a coal fire to chase what Pepe found — a scorching oven, a good hot stone, and the freshest littlenecks you can carry home will bring you honestly close. What lands on the table is New Haven in a single bite: spare, smoky, briny, and quietly certain that it has nothing left to prove.

WHITE CLAM APIZZA

An accidental topping at Frank Pepe's coal-fired oven turned into New Haven's most fiercely guarded pizza tradition: a sauceless pie piled with fresh littleneck clams.

Yield: One 12-inch pizza

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup warm water
- 1 tsp sugar
- 2 tsp active dry yeast
- 2 ½ cups all-purpose flour, plus more as needed
- 1 tsp salt
- 2 Tbsp olive oil
- 1 ½ cups shucked littleneck clams
- 3 cloves garlic, minced
- ¼ cup olive oil, plus more for drizzling
- ½ tsp dried oregano
- Red pepper flakes (optional)
- Pecorino Romano cheese, grated
- Parsley, for garnish

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Prepare the Dough*: In a large bowl, combine warm water, sugar, and yeast. Let stand for 5–10 minutes until foamy. Add flour, salt, and olive oil to the yeast mixture. Mix until a shaggy dough forms. Place the dough out onto a lightly floured surface and knead for 5–7 minutes, until smooth and elastic. After kneading dough, place the dough in a lightly oiled bowl, cover with plastic wrap, and let rise in a warm place for 1–2 hours, or until doubled in size.
2. *Prepare the Clams*: While the dough rises, shuck the littleneck clams, reserving their juice. Roughly chop the clams and set aside.
3. *Heat oven*: Preheat your oven to the highest temperature possible (ideally 500–550°F (260–288°C)) with a pizza stone or baking sheet inside.
4. *Assemble apizza*: Once the dough has risen, punch it down and divide it into two portions if you're making two smaller pizzas. On a lightly floured surface, stretch or roll out one portion of the dough into a thin circle (12 inches). Transfer the dough to the pizza peel dusted with cornmeal or flour. In a small bowl, combine the minced garlic, olive oil, oregano, and red pepper flakes (if using). Brush this mixture evenly over the pizza dough. Distribute the chopped clams evenly over the garlic-oil mixture. Lightly drizzle the pizza with a little more olive oil.
5. *Bake and Serve*: Carefully slide the pizza onto the hot pizza stone or baking sheet. Bake for 5–7 minutes, or until the crust is golden brown and slightly charred in spots. Remove the pizza from the oven and let it cool for a few minutes. Sprinkle the baked pizza with grated Pecorino Romano cheese. Garnish with chopped fresh parsley. Slice and serve immediately.

NOTES & TIPS

- Thin Crust: The crust should be thin, crisp, and slightly charred, not overly chewy or doughy.
- Simple Toppings: The focus is on the clams, garlic, and olive oil. Avoid adding too many other ingredients that might overwhelm the delicate flavor.
- High Heat: A very hot oven is essential for achieving the characteristic crisp crust and quick cooking time.
- Quality Ingredients: Use fresh littleneck clams, good quality olive oil, and freshly grated Pecorino Romano cheese for the best flavor.

